

has facilitated an easy passage for Pakistan's ISI-backed terrorist groups who want to carry out operations in India.

For India, the new Government's stand on key issues such as the 1950 Indo-Nepal Friendship and Peace Treaty, and the extradition treaty, which has to be ratified by Nepal, will be the first litmus test of bilateral ties with the new Himalayan republic. But instead of worrying about the fact that a Maoist regime in Kathmandu may fuel the Naxalite problem, India should see it as an opportunity to hardsell the Nepalese success story to the Maoists here.

The economy is in a shambles, which has added to Nepal's woes. Political turmoil has led to a slump in tourism, with travellers choosing to skip this picturesque hilly destination to avoid trouble. India, which powers Nepal's economy, will increase its assistance once the new government takes over. It has already put aside \$100 million (Rs 420 crore) as credit for Nepal to support development projects.

On the broader geopolitical landscape, India will have to reassert its dominant role in the region. To do this, it will have to use a mix of economic and political levers and persuasion to ensure that the Prachanda-led Maoist regime does not ape King Gyanendra and sit in the lap of China. There is already some indication that the Maoists may be soft on their ideological cousins in China. Recently, a Nepalese Maoist minister even visited the country. With the US and the Western countries seeking to expand their foothold in Nepal, India will have to balance the power equation. From the beginning, it has been uneasy about the United Nations getting into its backyard, and would prefer the early exit of the global body.

India should be able to influence and advise Nepal as it takes the historic first steps towards writing a Constitution. The largest democracy in the world needs to play a pro-active role to ensure full support to its Himalayan neighbour so as to enable it to form a government of the people, by the people, and for the people.

INTERVIEW | **PRACHANDA**

"WE HAVE SET AN EXAMPLE BY MOVING FROM BULLET TO BALLOT"

It's not often that a prime minister-elect drives halfway across town to meet a journalist for an interview. But that's Prachanda, the 53-year-old Communist whose demeanour hides the fact that he is Nepal's prime minister-in-waiting. He moves around in a heavily-protected Mahindra Scorpio with his guards drawn from the notorious Red Army as well as the Nepal Police. Despite winning only a third of the Constituent Assembly seats, the man instrumental in overthrowing Nepal's 240-year-old monarchy is confident of dictating the politics of the world's youngest republic. He spoke for more than an hour with INDIA TODAY Editor Prabhu Chawla for Seedhi Baat on Aaj Tak channel. Excerpts:

Q. How did an underground leader like you manage to form a multi-party government in Nepal?

A. This is a new political model

that we are trying to set up. We had decided in favour of a multi-party system some eight years ago. We are trying to evolve and change it according to changing times.

Q. Am I talking to the new prime minister or the President of the country? Will you still carry on with your violent ways?

A. Now that we have begun the peace process, resorting to violence is out of question. Until the provisions of the Constitution are laid down, you can call me the new prime minister.

Q. Who will have more power—the President or you?

A. The President will just be a ceremonial head. The executive powers will remain with the prime minister.

Q. Why don't you appoint Girija Prasad Koirala as the President?

A. I have political and moral issues with appointing him as the